

A Holy Wood story

—“Abrangih, why are you not coming in?”

Her friend turns around surprised.

—“Oh, Borān, I . . . I didn’t see you there. I thought. . .”

—“ . . . that I was inside keeping a seat for you on our cushion. Yeah, I was. But then I noticed that you were already here. But you didn’t come in? Why?”

She had slipped out the other side and then ran to catch Abrangih outside the door.

—“I was . . . I didn’t want to disturb. . .”

—“Abrangih, don’t lie to me!”

—“Okay, I was avoiding him.”

—“My brother?,” she lifts her chin. So, not that stupid Shirowe. Aha, her cousin then! He always wants to chat Abrangih up. She’s sure he has a crush on her friend, “Farroḡzād?”

But then she realizes that he is not even here, so that didn’t make sense.

—“No. Varaz!”

—“What? Why would you want to avoid him? It’s him we want to tell us stories. And he is about to begin so we’d better go in.”

They quickly go inside, leaving her question unanswered. She’ll ask her later.

—“Aha, my fair female fans,” the *darigbed* [majordomo] told him that the Spahbedān boys would not be here today, so his audience—Shirowe inclusive—is complete, and seeing their eager faces, ready for today’s story, “So, children. I think I still owe you a story, one I did not complete yet.”

—“Oh, yeah, Varaz. You have to tell us what happened when the Princess and the Knight stepped out of the mouth of Younā the Whale and evil Shamiram was waiting for them. What happened?”

Not the story he had in mind, but now that Āzar has brought it up, he’d better come up with a fitting conclusion. A trial to his improvisation skills. And he just has the idea: why not turn the whole thing upside down, ha, ha.

—“Ah, yes, a most titillating twist to a tantalizing trial. An enigmatic end to an entertaining exploit. Incredible, simply incredible,” he shakes his head, which makes them all look at him with pleading eyes, “I would tell you, but you guys are not going to believe me. And you’re going to make

fun of me. So, I don't know..."

—"Oh, come on, Varaz? We'll believe you."

—"I won't!"

—"Perhaps, this time, your brother might be right!"

—"We won't be like Shirowe, Varaz, we promise."

—"Alright, I'll tell you. But please don't shoot the messenger."

SO, there they are, outside Younā's big mouth, blinking their eyes against the blazing sunlight—inside the whale's belly it was pretty dark—and then, to their horror, they see the evil Queen running towards them. They can hear her sinister laughter while she is holding something menacing. It looks like a silver shield. What is she up to now?

~"Oh, no, my lovely Princess, she is holding the Disk of Death, I think."

~"My valiant Knight, brace yourself. Shamiram will hit us on the head with it."

~"Or worse!" And so, they plant their feet firmly in the ground, ready for the terrible blow on their heads. But, children, it is not their heads, the Queen is coming for. 🍪

—"Oh, no, Varaz, for what then?"

—"Their tummies!"

—"Huh?"

JUST when they expect her brutal assault, Shamiram swings the silver plate in front of them and... she offers them:

~"You guys want some *shiftenag* [marzipan]. Straight from the royal kitchens. They are delish!," our heroic duo look at each other puzzled. Is this a trick to poison them? But the Queen must have guessed their suspicion, for she grabs one of them and starts nibbling enthusiastically on it, "Hmm, only the Princess can make them this good."

~"The Princess?"

~"Yes, the Princess of Sweetness. She has this contraption—I think it is called hide-the-batter—with which she can make these cookies to perfection."

~"But why would it hide the batter..." The Princess pokes the Knight in his side. That is not the issue now. They need to find out what is really going on.

~“Did you incarcerate the poor princess!”

~“What? Incarcerate the lovely Princess of Sweetness? No, no, she is still in her castle, giving guidance to lost souls.”

~“But... but...” They cannot figure out what that perfidious Queen is up to.

~“Oh, I see. You think... that I took... the princess,... ha, ha. Yeah, normally I would do those things, ha, ha. But not today!”

~“Not today?”

~“Wait. You don’t know what day it is today?”

What is so special about today, they wonder.

~“The day that we catch you in flagrante delicto!”

~“Although, my Princess, it seems more in delicioso flavor.” Oh, no, children. Might the Knight have been fooled by the Queen’s friendly demeanor. He is eating one of the *shiftenag* cookies! 🍪

—“Is it a potion, Varaz?”

—“Well, it seems...”

THE cookies are really yummy, for he wants to take another one. The Princess looks angrily at him.

~“What are you doing, my vacillating Knight! You cannot trust her!”

~“But, perhaps, today...?” The Princess turns angrily to the Queen.

~“Confess to your ploy, evil Queen!”

~“Wow! You really don’t know what day it is today!”

~“Do not befuddle me with your riddle! Do not besmirch me with your smirk!” The Knight puts his hand on his lovely companion’s arm and shakes his head.

~“Let it go, my sweetness, today is not the day. Leave sorrow to tomorrow!” Oh, no, the Queen’s spell is taking its effect on him!

~“Listen to your noble companion,” now the Princess is convinced that something is up—evil Shamiram would never call her friend noble, “have one of these Persian delicacies. For today, we celebrate... Quirky Queen day!”

~“Huh?”

~“Yeah, you can’t imagine how exhausting it is to be evil, twenty-four hours a day, seven days a week,” she shakes her head, “plotting and scheming. There are so many princesses to capture, so many governors to corrupt. . . . And so, one day, we Queen all got together and we decided that there should be one day in the year that we celebrate our sacred secret sororal societal sisterhood! Were you not informed? After all, a Princess is just a Queen in the making. So, sister, let’s enjoy this day with merrymaking and some delicious *shiftenag*.” The Princess is still not believing it, but her Knight is nodding so enthusiastically that she thinks ~“What the hell. . . .” And she picks up one of the cookies and starts nibbling too. And . . . they are really very yummy. And so, they sit, in the late afternoon sun, in the meadow of Nainavā, drinking pomegranate juice and eating those yummy *shiftenag*, celebrating the queerness of Quirky Queen’s day, while Younā the Whale is happily leaping up and down in the lake. And they reminisce of their past adventures and exploits.

~“Remember, that one day, you grabbed an elephant by its trunk and swung it at us, to squash us, but we jumped away and instead, you hit that mouse?”

~“Yeah, pfew, that was one angry mouse!”

~“Ha, ha.” And other funny anecdotes like that. And thus, children, comes our story of the whale who wanted to wail to its joyful conclusion: a happy ending once more. Oh, in case you wonder, the Princess and the Knight politely declined to stay over the night at the Queen’s palace. For the next morning. . . , the gods only know what she would have done with them. ❧

—“What a cockamamie story! There is no such thing as a Quirky Queen day!”

—“Well, if there was, I don’t think they would tell us, Shirowe,” to avoid the girls or, God forbid, the queen to start dwelling on this invention of him—was it really an invention, ha, ha—he jumps up and exclaims, “But that was not the story I wanted to tell you, children. There is another loose end we have to tie up. A story of great valor and piety. A true Holy wood

story!"

—"Hollywood?"

—"Yes, remember, children, when the Princess's cousin, poor Ingunda had been petrified and they needed the Holy Wood of the True Cross so that Queen Holycrux could imbue their *Espiskevi* spell with divine glory?"

—"Oh, yeah. What cross was that again, Varaz."

—"The very cross on which our Lord IESOUS ΧRISTOS had been crucified. You guys have heard of IESOUS, right?"

Mommy and mom Shirin and aunt Peristerá pray to him, but just to clarify for her friend Abrangih, she explains.

—"Yes, his name was ISĀ and he wanted the people to stop sinning and so he crucified himself so that GOD could save him!" Not exactly how the canons would proclaim it, but close enough for his current story.

—"Something like that, ha, ha. And for that, they have to go to the Holy City."

—"The Holy City, where is that?"

—"Hierosolyma, that's what the *Hromāyig* [Roman] call it, but it is in the land of the Jews and they call it Urishlim [Jerusalem]."

—"I thought the Jews live here, across the river, in Veh Ardashir?"

—"Well, they also live here, but they first lived in that city, which is far from here and it is also where our Lord IESOUS has been crucified. And so, the remains of the cross are now kept there too."

Mommy Shirin always tells them about their saints and how their bones are worshiped in sanctuaries all over the world. So, they must surely also do this with the holy ISĀ.

—"And also ISĀ's remains?"

The children don't really seem to get the subtleties of their faith—probably, for an outsider, it sounded a little . . . contrived anyway. But he is not going into theological debates now, so he quickly shrugs it away.

—"Well, those are in Heaven now, so no."

BUT the True Cross, it is there in that city, and they just need a little piece of it. So powerful is it, that just a splinter would suffice.

~"My Knight, should we go to the Emperor to ask for his permission?"

~"Frankly, my Princess, I'd rather not, lest the Emperor changes his mind and sends those three Dev against us again."

~“Yeah, let’s not go there. If we can convince the Patriarch of the Holy City, then we’re fine.”

~“Okay, then, let’s go find the Patriarch!” And off they go, to the Holy City. But when they get to the episcopal palace, they find the Patriarch with his head in his hands. And they can hear him sob loudly.

~“Your Eminence, is everything okay?”

~“Oh, noble Princess, the end is neigh. God has forsaken us!”

~“Oh dear.” That doesn’t sound too good, so they insist he tell them what has happened.

~“For the last three days, I have been having this disturbing dream . . . and now it has all come true.”

~“What did you dream, Your Eminence?”

~“Of the Archangel Gabriyel coming to me and saying ‘Read!’, and I ask what should I read, and He replies ‘That what man was taught he no longer knows.’¹ But when I wanted to ask what men had forgotten, he disappeared. And then the following night, Archangel Gabriyel again comes to me and He says ‘Proclaim!’ And I ask what should I proclaim, and the angel replies ‘That all flesh has turned grass’.² I didn’t know what He meant and then as sudden as He had appeared, the Angel of God disappeared again. But then last night, Gabriyel came back and He was angrier than ever and He spoke to me once more in words I did not understand. So, I pleaded with him to explain His message. And this is what Gabriyel told me.”

~“The Lord of the Heavens and the Sky has appointed Me, Gabriyel, Angel of Fire, to make the ministering angel of the Persians swallow the letter in which it was written that in the kingdom of Persia, there are those who pay taxes and there are those who do not pay taxes.³ And thus, in His mercifulness for mankind, the Lord anointed Me as mankind’s guardian angel. And so, I went tirelessly to work, to steer

¹Quran, 96:5.

²Isaiah, 40:6.

³Yoma Mishna, 77a.

mankind into the right direction. A prod here, a nudge there. And when, after a few centuries, it seemed mankind finally was getting it, I decided to reward mankind with a divine gift, the Key of Surrection. And so, in a dream, I sent Judas the Apostate to the Holy Helena, and I forced him to reveal the location of the Key of Surrection. And the Holy Helena found it in the place Judas the Apostate showed her and she posited it in a golden shrine for all mankind to benefit from its healing power. And for thus damning the devil to fire perdurable,⁴ I baptized Judas as the lordly Patriarch of Jerusalem. And thus, having settled affairs, I thought to Myself, all is good and I think I deserve a little nap. Just one, perhaps two centuries tops. But what do I notice at my awakening from My holy Power Nap: mankind has turned against itself. One unkind man says, the Godhead is one, and the second unkind man says the Godhead is two and the third unkind man says it is three, and then all the other kind of men scream something even more preposterous. As if mankind's puny brain can compute the numeracy of the Lord of the Heavens and the Sky. No, you do not deserve the Key of Surrection and I will put it back in its original place! And then, in some forlorn desert, I shall awaken a new prophet to seal mankind's fate and hopefully then they will learn. Stupid children!" The Patriarch starts sobbing again.

~"Your Eminence, what did the Archangel mean with the Key of Surrection?"

~"I was not sure either, but I had a suspicion at the mention of the saintly Helena, the mother of our beloved Emperor Konstantinos. So, this morning, I went to the Church of the Holy Sepulcher, and when I opened the shrine," he starts to sob again that they barely hear what he's saying, "the ... Holy Wood... of the True... Cross is ... no... more."

~"That was the Key of Surrection?" Our Knight asks

~"And shouldn't it be the Key of Resurrection?"

~"Well, apparently, you have to surrect before you can res-

⁴Golden Legend, III.184.

urrect. What do I know? It doesn't matter, for it is gone! The deacons who were there that night reported seeing a large body of fire, blazing but not consuming, so that the whole spot seemed to be in flames,⁵ and then suddenly, the light was gone. And with it, all hope for mankind." And the bishop throws himself on the floor weeping loudly. Well, children, that is not good news for our intrepid duo either, for now they cannot get a piece anymore to take to Queen Holycrux. 🕯

—"They have to find it, Varaz, the Key!"

E xactly what they are thinking too.

~"Princess, how are we going to find the Key of the Holy Wood or whatever it is called?"

~"Well, my kind Knight, Queen Helena might come to our rescue."

~"Huh, my favorite kind of Princess? Is she not long dead?"

~"Well, I meant, her story. How she found the Holy Wood of the True Cross. Did the Archangel not say that he put it back in its place. Well, the saintly Helena had looked for the mount on which the Cross had been erected to crucify IESOUS, and then she had dug in that mount and had found it. That's where it must be now again, my even kinder Knight."

~"Hmm, I don't know whether you noticed, my kinda Princess, but there are plenty of hills here. The Archangel could have buried it in any one of them and I don't think he was so kind to put up on the hillside a big sign saying Holy Wood."

~"No, that would indeed be silly, my kindest Knight. But there is another clue!"

~"A clue?"

~"A temple!"

~"You mean, like a Church?"

~"No, a heathen temple, as the story goes, the Holy Wood was buried underneath a pagan shrine." As it happens, two young men are passing by and they seem in a jolly mood.

~"Hello, visitors from abroad. Welcome to the City. I am Emmaus and this is my friend Cleopas."

⁵Evagrios Σχολastikos, IV.26.

~“Greetings, dear lads, you seem in good spirit. Where are you heading?”

~“Are you the only strangers in Jerusalem who do not know the things that have taken place here?⁶”

~“Uhm, what do you mean?”

~“The new place! It’s the hottest in town! Everyone’s raving about it.”

~“A new place?”

~“Well, yeah, the Joint der Fertilizers.”

~“Fertility, dude, the Den of Fertility!”

~“Oh, yes, ha, ha, that one. Anyway, that’s where we’re headed. They say there are some nice fish to catch, if you catch my drift.” The Knight shakes his head.

~“Youth nowadays!” But the Princess realizes something.

~“My Knighthood’s kind, that’s it! That’s where we need to go!”

~“What, now you wanna go party too, my one of a kind Princess?”

~“No, silly, don’t you get it. Den of Fertility, . . . , Goddess of Fertility. . . AFRODITE. . . That’s to Whom the temple was dedicated under which the Holy Wood was buried. And now, suddenly it is back. If that’s not a Holy Wood sign!” And so, they quickly run after the two party goers and find the hill in which the Archangel has buried the Cross. And while Emmaus and Cleopas catch their fish dancing into the night, they start digging. And digging. . . and digging. And then suddenly, clonk! That sounded like wood. And when they dig a little more, lo and behold, a cross. . . but then . . . another one. . . and a third one! 🍷

—“Three Crosses? They needed that many crosses to hang ISĀ?”

—“No, ha, ha.”

With Our Lord, they had crucified two common thieves and so not one, but three crosses were buried at that site. But now our twosome face another problem. Which is the True one, on which did they hang IESOUS, King of the Jews? 🍷

⁶Luke, 24.18.

—“He was their King? They crucified their King?”
 —“No, that’s what they accused Him of, but he was not a worldly King but a heavenly one. And apparently, those you can crucify.”
 —“Varaz, I am a still confused. Is ISĀ not a *Tarsāg* [Christian]? How can he be a Jew then?”
 —“Ah, well, he was a Jew who ushered in a new era and that’s why He is called the ΧΡΙΣΤΟΣ and his followers call themselves god-fearing Christians.”

BUT all that does not solve their conundrum, for the crosses look identical.

~“My Princess, I thought that this beacon was covered in gold, with gems that stood fair at its corners, five up on the cross-beam.⁷”

~“While humanity wallows in vanity, divinity hallows modesty. Archangel Gabriyel must have stripped it back to its original form.”

~“But how then will we know which is the True one?”

~“The Litmus of the Holy Helena, my Knight.”

~“Lid mass? I thought it was called Roodmas.”

~“No, Knight of Silliness, Litmus, it’s a test.”

~“*Alā*, then enlighten me, Light of my life.”

~“The saintly Helena found an old sickly crone, at the brink of death, and she brought her to the first cross. And she convinced her that she would be healed upon touching the precious cross.⁸ But nothing happened. So, she made her touch the sec. . .”

~“Okay, I see where this is going, so let’s just skip to the third one.”

~“You guessed it, my impatient Knight, upon touching the third, its healing powers were revealed and that’s how Helena knew she had found the Key of Surrection.”

~“Alright, all we need to do then is to find some sickly old woman and make her touch it.” And as if Providence is looking out for our duo, an old woman just passes by.

⁷Dream of the Rood, 8-10.

⁸Socrates Scholasticus, 17.

~“Mother dear, how fare you?”

~“Don’t you see how old age has bent me in half, don’t you see the hump outgrowing my neck, my hair falling out to be replaced by warts and boils, don’t you see—for I, with my cataracts, sure don’t see much anymore—me limping on my swollen feet with my crooked toes and ingrown nails. Oh, and would you look at that, I have a single tooth left,” she opens her mouth to show them—not a very appetizing sight, children, “and it hurts as hell. So, you tell me, how do I fare?”

~“Well, mother dear, your calvary shall end here—literally—after you touched the Holy Wood upon which our Lord was crucified. Come hither, and touch this wood to receive its beneficial powers.”

~“What? I am not touching that! Look how dirty it is. God knows what diseases fester in its woods. Am I not already suffering enough? Be gone, evil enchantress!” The Knight wants to come to his friend’s honor, but she puts her hand on his arm while shaking her head.

~“It is already happening as the Patriarch feared. Mankind has lost its faith in the divine!”

~“Forget about that senile woman. I am sure we can find some other poor soul that needs the Holy Wood treatment.” But, children, alas the Princess is right. Whomever they approach, they curse and execrate them, calling them quacks and charlatans. So, what are they to do? 🐼

—“Perhaps they should touch it themselves and get cured from that silly superstition.”

—“Clever, Shirowe, thus proving it was no superstition! The paradox of the orthodox, ha, ha. I am afraid it is not going to work this way.”

SO they sit down, disheartened by mankind’s lack of faith. Until a little bird... 🐼

—“A white falcon, Varaz? They always help, right?”

She has to make up with her friend Abrangih for the things she had said the other day—and also for sneaking upon her today—and Abrangih, she likes stories about white falcons. Her friend looks indeed very pleased with her suggestion.

Not exactly.

~“O, look, my Knight, that bird.”

~“The little sparrow?”

~“It’s not a sparrow, my love, it’s a nothingale.” The Knight looks puzzled. 🐦

—“Varaz, did the Princess not say it wrong? It’s a...”

—“Let me cut you off there, Āzar, because there is a twist, so heinous...”

The Princess explains

~“Do you know why they are called that way, my Knight in shining armor?”

~“No, enlighten me further, my Princess in glowing gown.”

~“It is because they do not sing.”

~“*Alā*, chicken don’t sing either. But they don’t go announcing it with such a silly name.”

~“Ah, but that’s just it. They used to.”

~“How is that possible?”

~“Well, it’s all the malevolence of Queen Shamiram. You know what evil hates most: beauty and joy. And there were these birds who sang so beautifully and joyfully in the night and that’s why they were called nightingales. But wicked Shamiram spited their purity and so she weaved this powerful curse that none of these birds could no longer sing at night. And so, these fair feathered friends became nothingales.”

~“But is there no Law against such despicable acts? You told me about the Law Code of the wizard Hammurabi. Didn’t he proscribed such evilness?”

~“There is a Law, but it has the averse effect, I am afraid.”

~“What stupid law is that?”

~“The Law of Natural Selection.”

~“Huh?”

~“See, whenever one of those lovely birds tried to sing at night, Shamiram’s curse made them just tumble of their branch and they fell down on the ground, dead. And so, each time one tried, it lost its life and in the end, there were none left brave enough to go against Shamiram curse, and now, they all have become nothingales.”

~“A sad, sad tale, my Princess. But what’s in its tail?”

~“The solution to our conundrum: we let the little bird touch the Holy Wood and its divine magic will counter Shami-ram’s evil spell and the bird will again become a nightingale to regale the nights with its joyful songs.”

~“Clever!” And so, with its little beak, the nightingale touches the first cross and ... nothing happens. They look at each other, until the Knight realizes.

~“It’s still day, my love. Didn’t you say they only sing at night?”

~“You’re right, my knight, let’s sit tight until fall of night.” And so they wait for the sun to set. And when it gets dark, they light a torch and invite the bird to sit with them. It likes the company and it starts to ... pick at some seeds.

~“I don’t think it worked, my Knight-in-the-dark.”

~“Well, we have two more crosses to go, so, we’ll try tomorrow, my Princess-sleep-tight.” And so, the next morning, they take the little bird to the second cross and have its little beak touch the Holy Wood—well, they hope that it is the right one this time. But it is still light, so they have to wait until evening comes again.

~“My princess,” he twiddles his thumbs and pretends to be the Knight waiting idly, “we didn’t really think this through, didn’t we?” She sighs and yawns and sits down on the trunk of a fallen tree and puts her head in her hands.

~“Nope, not our smartest idea, I must admit. But we must persevere, my Knight.” Now children, can you guess what happened next? 🐦

—“Nothing?”

—“Exactly.”

When day turns into night, the bird, apart from a few tweets to her friends, remains silent. And so, the next morn, they repeat the whole thing, with the third cross and when night falls... they anxiously look at the bird. What if these were just some random crosses? After all, the *Hromā-yig* [Roman] punished a lot of thieves in those days.

~“What’s up with those two,” the bird thinks, “why are

they staring at me like that. I'm going to babble ... blabble ... blolble... bulble... bul... bulbul bülbülbül." And before they know it, they are greeted by the most beautiful song man has ever heard. The nightingale's craft has been restored through the miraculous workings of the Holy Wood! 🐦

—"Yay!"

SO, they quickly hurry back to the Patriarch. Right in time, children, for the poor sod was about to hang himself in utter despair.

~"Your Beautitude, do no longer despair. The nightingale sings again."

~"Good to hear that birdkind is flourishing. An omen confirming that mankind's time has past," he looks even more dispirited as he puts the noose around his neck, "there is no hope but the rope!"

~"Oh, and we also found the True Cross," the Knight looks at his friend, "perhaps we should have led with that." Upon hearing these glad tidings, the Patriarch rejoices and sings and dances and taps all around.

~"Holy Wood is back!"

~"But, Your Eminence, can we please not squander again this gift from heaven?"

~"Fickle are humanity's children. What have you me do?"

~"They should stop already to bicker whether ΧΡΙΣΤΟΣ is one, or two, or three."

~"You're so right, Princess, but the anagnorisis of an anamnestic anathema, not something one does in one-two-three."

~"Ha, ha." But the Patriarch doesn't mean it as a joke, as he replies

~"What you ask of me is to become the Ecumenical Patriarch of the Church. That is not going to fly well with the Pope. Now that the whole Church is torn apart, its holy laws, its venerable synods, even the very commands of our Lord ΙΗΣΟΥΣ ΧΡΙΣΤΟΣ are torn apart by the invention of some arrogant and pompous talk, and for that I shall need to bind

all sick men with bonds of august authority.⁹"

~"Well, Your Eminence, good luck with that. We humbly ask to just give us a mere splinter of the Holy Wood, so that we can bring it to Queen Holycrux that she can heal the sick."

~"And decalcify your poor cousin, my Princess."

~"Huh?"

~"It's a long story, Your Eminence, and it has already been told to the children."

~"May the children of man fare well then. Farewell."

~"Xaire [Bye], Your Eminence." And so, children, did the Princess and the Knight once more save the day. And even the night, for now all over the world, the joyous song of nightingales can be heard again. ♪

He makes a little bow, to indicate the end of his storytelling. A little uncharacteristic for him, Shirowe steps forward and asks, loud enough for the others to hear.

—"That Shamiram's curse, does it also work on annoying princesses singing all day dumb songs?"

She throws him a dark look. But perhaps she should just do as Varaz, laugh it off.

—"Ha, ha."

After the children have left, he turns to the *Bāmbishn*, to gauge the effect of his tale.

—"A rectification of a conflation. According to the hagiographers, it was under Emperor Ioulianos, whom they call the Apostate, that patriarch Judas was martyred for helping Queen Helena recover the True Cross," yeah, he seemed to have mixed those two up. So, he beats his chest three times, although, the *Bāmbishn* might not get his *mea culpa*—oh, who is he kidding, of course she knows, "And also a query: was the veiled accusation about abstruse christological schisms intentional?"

As always, the *Bāmbishn* gets it! Regarding this issue, he also agrees with Queen Shirin—as if he ever was going to disagree with his favorite queen—who herself is trying to unify the factions. He is pleased that his story has had the intended effect on the *Bāmbishn*. Social critique, master Pahrabad had called it.

⁹Pope Gregory, 5.35.

~“A subtle game that when overplayed brings forth the demise of many a minstrel.”

~“So, why then the risk?”

He had asked, to which his master had replied.

~“For no one else can. That is our gift, young Varaz. That’s why we disguise as satyrs to disseminate our satire.”

—“It is a shame, Your Grace, that my coreligionists cannot put aside their differences.”

—“Except under the banner of a potent icon, such as the True Cross, as your story might have unintentionally demonstrated.”

Wow. That is something he never considered. The *Bāmbishn* is not just smart, she’s supersmart. Perhaps, she should be his favorite queen! Just as she is leaving with little Shasha, she turns around.

—“The involute device commandeered by Queen Shirin to perfect the recipe of *shiftenag* [marzipan] is called a *hydrometer*.”

—“Ha, ha, that hide-the-batter thing didn’t make any sense. Thanks for the clarification.” That *shirin* [sweet] *shiftenag* is the best, so, perhaps Queen Shirin is still his favorite. Although, one must wonder who then built that device?